The World and Mr. Chicken

By Paul Feig

INTRODUCTION

When I was five, my older brother convinced me that a monster lived under my bed. It didn't matter that I had examined the space between my mattress and floor a dozen times. It didn't matter that there was not a shred of evidence to support his existence. As soon as the lights were turned off, the possibility that a monster could be lurking under my bed transformed into a real and frightening fact. (whispering) – Sometimes I still check . . . just to be sure.

Let's face it we all have some irrational fear . . . even as adults. But in The World and Mr. Chicken, Paul Feig claims the title as the MOST paranoid and MOST gullible! The World and Mr. Chicken by Paul Feig

I was a huge chicken when I was a kid.

It's hard to say why, exactly. I mean, most kids are scared of one thing or another, but I just seemed to be afraid of absolutely everything.

Loud noises always scared me. Up until about the age of six, I always reacted to a thunderstorm in

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the same way: I'd clamp my hands over my ears and refuse to take them off until the thunder stopped, the storm clouds cleared, and the sun came back out. The loud rumbles and claps of thunder sounded to me as if the earth were exploding and about to fall apart, and I guess I figured that if I could keep the sound out of my head, I could somehow make myself exempt from the world's destruction. If it was thundering during a meal and my parents wanted me to eat, one of them would have to feed me by hand because my palms would not leave my ears even if I was on the verge of starvation. I'd put my arms up and elbows out to the sides and clamp my hands so solidly onto the sides of my skull that the Jaws of Life couldn't pry them off. I looked like a human loving cup, the living booby prize for my poor parents, who were quickly discovering that their only child was a neurotic mess.

My first experience in a movie theater went from fun to frightening when my mother took me to a double feature that saw a Winnie the Pooh cartoon

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inexplicably programmed on the same bill with the Rat Pack's Roaring Twenties bootlegger musical *Robin and the 7 Hoods*. Sammy Davis Jr. sang, jumped up on a bar, danced a few steps, then pulled out a tommy gun and started firing wildly. As a trucker might say, I was "off like the bride's panties" and cowering in the lobby before Sammy finished his first verse.

Circuses scared the hell out of me, both because performers always seemed to be shooting off giant cannons all the time and because the disturbing, antics of the creepy clowns usually involved blowing something up or hitting each other with exploding sticks that would crack loudly like gunshots. As the kids around me were cheering and laughing at these allegedly comedic exploits, I would fleeing for the parking lot like an extra in a Godzilla movie.

Those clowns also played into another of my major fears: I was afraid of anyone in a costume. A trip to see Santa might as well have been a trip to sit on Hitler's lap for all the trauma it would cause

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me. Once, when I was four, my mother and I were in a Sears and someone wearing an enormous Easter Bunny costume headed my way to present me with a chocolate Easter egg. I was petrified by this nightmarish six-foot-tall bipedal pink fake-fur monster with human-sized arms and legs and a soulless, impassive face heading toward me. It waved halfheartedly as it held a piece of candy out in an evil attempt to lure me into its clutches. Fearing for my life, I pulled open the bottom drawer of a display case and stuck my head inside, the same way an ostrich buries its head in the sand. Over the next several years, I would run away in terror from a guy in a gorilla suit whose job it was to wave customers into a car wash, a giant Uncle Sam on stilts, a midget dressed like a leprechaun, Ronald McDonald, Big Bird, and Bozo the Clown. Add to this an irrational fear of small dogs that saw me on more than one occasion fleeing in terror from our neighbor's four-inch-high miniature dachshund as if I were being chased by the Hound of the Baskervilles and a chronic case of

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germ phobia, and it's pretty apparent that I was what some of the less politically correct among us might call-a first-class *wussy*.

Even though I tried to conquer my fears as I went through grade school and junior high, convincing myself that loud noises could be cool when they came in the form of firecrackers blowing up model cars and Led Zeppelin albums turned up full blast, and teaching myself that people in costumes are usually only present when an event is supposed to be "fun," I would still succumb to a fear of anything unknown. Especially if the unknown meant I was potentially going to get my ass kicked. One of the biggest unknowns I feared was high school.

A lot of my more irrational fears as a kid came from the fact that my next-door neighbor Mary and her older sisters used to love to scare the crap out of me. They'd always tell me horror stories about things that would happen if I did something or other. They're the ones who, when we were all at the beach, put the fear of God in me that I might

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spontaneously combust because "it happened to this kid over on Moravian Drive after he stayed out in the sun too long." They made me paranoid for years about a mythical "sewing bee" that reportedly flew into kids' bedrooms and sewed their mouths and nostrils shut in the middle of the night so that they'd smother to death. And to this day, I'm still afraid to put my cold hands in hot water because they told me if I did, my fingers would fall off. Looking back, I know that they were merely having fun with my perpetual fears and my chronic gullibility. And in the weeks before I was to enter high school, their minds reeled at the opportunity to ruin something I was actually starting to look forward to.

One summer evening, I was sitting with them in the ditch in their front yard listening to seventeen-year-old Becky, the eldest girl in their family, explain to us what hermaphrodites were, she suddenly looked at me and said . . . *.(in Becky's voice)* "So, Fig Newton, you're starting high school next

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month, huh? You better be careful. They don't like freshmen very much." A hot flush immediately went up the back of my neck.

"They don't?" *(trying not to sound worried)*

"Nope, you should see what they do to freshmen. Sometimes, if you're walking down the hall, a bunch of seniors will grab you, drag you into the bathroom, and give you a swirly.

I looked at Sharon and Mary, who were listening to Becky, wide-eyed. "What's a swirly?"

"It's when they stick your head in the toilet and flush it. Last year, some kid drowned. The year before, another kid got sucked down. They found him in the sewer. Long and skinny and dead."

(feeling faint) "Really?"

"Yeah. But that's nothing," *(leaning forward and whispering).* "A lot of times, what they'll do is grab a freshman, drag him into the bathroom, and make him eat drugs."

I was now officially in a panic. My dad had just the other night given me the world's most

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sobering talk about drugs after he and I came across a picture of a hippie shooting up heroin in an antidrug ad in *National Geographic.*

(in Dad's Voice) (sighing, pointing at the picture and very adamant) "You see that kid? That kid is the stupidest kid you'll ever see. And you know why he's so stupid? Because what you see him doing, right there, is throwing his life away. Right down the toilet." My father then launched into a one-hour lecture, telling me that if I took drugs, any drugs - if I decided it'd be fun to "get all *doped* up" - I'd turn into a vegetable. Immediately. And all of a sudden, there I was in the ditch hearing that a group of crazed seniors were going to put me in a coma the minute I entered the school on my first day. I came home very upset.

"Mom! I'm not going to high school. No way!"

"Of course you are. What are you talking about?"

"I'm just not going. Forget it!"

"Why not?"

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"Because they're gonna make me eat *drugs.*"

Who is?"

"Seniors. They hate freshmen. This kid was walking down the hall last year and a bunch of seniors jumped him and stuck his head in the toilet and made him eat drugs!"

"Oh, my goodness," my mother said, extremely concerned. "I'll call the school tomorrow."

The next day, my mom told me that she had talked to Mr. Walker, the principal of the high school. Apparently, she tracked down the poor guy's home phone number and bothered him during his summer vacation because of my paranoia.

"I spoke to the principal today," *(embarrassed)*

(as Paul to audience) Clearly he had convinced her that her son was crazy.

"He said he wasn't aware that any of this toilet and drug business was going on but that he'd look into it. He told me to tell you not to worry,

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though. He said it was probably just a story."

Between my mother's face and my reading between the lines of what the principal said, I immediately felt like the dumbest kid in the world. I started imagining the conversation that must have taken place between my mother and the principal.

"Mr. Walker, my son says that the older boys in your school force the younger ones to eat drugs."

"Um . . . *who* is your son?"

"Paul Feig."

"Feig? I don't seem to recall the name."

"Well, he's not in high school yet. He starts next month."

"Oh, well . . . I think he's just been told some wild stories by some students having a little fun with him."

"So, you don't think it actually happens?"

"I sincerely doubt it, Mrs. Feig. If the kids have any drugs, I really doubt they're going to waste them on your son."

And then he probably hung up and mentally

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filed the name "Paul Feig" in the Whining Little Idiots folder.

That night, we had a very loud thunderstorm, and as I lay in bed and listened to the thunder claps rattle my bedroom window I started to hate myself for having spent my life up to that point being such a wuss.

When I got to high school the next month, still nervous and on guard, just in case Becky was right and I was going to be jumped, dunked, and turned into an addict, I found that high school wasn't the jungle I was imagining it would be. After a few days of being looked through like the Invisible Man by sophomores, juniors, and seniors, all of whom were having more fun than I was, I found myself with a new and actually legitimate fear - the fear of being completely ignored. I suddenly wished that even one of the older kids in my school would find me noticeable enough to merit a swirly or a forced meal of their stash.

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Because, after all, if people are sticking your head in a toilet or shoving drugs down your throat, at least they're paying attention to you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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